While Pottinger and Haughton, who both had horses, eventually made it through to Kabul, riding by night far from the main road, along the western flank of the Koh Daman, and hiding by day, only a handful of their sepoys limped in after them. Among those captured and enslaved was Havildar Moti Ram, who uniquely left an account of his capture. Moti Ram made it further than most, and was captured when within sight of his destination. ‘At the time hostilities broke out,’ he wrote, ‘there were two Gurkha fakirs in the fort who were visiting on a pilgrimage the different Hindoo shrines of Afghanistan.’ These fakirs demanded arms and ammunition.

> Our officers complied with their requests, and these sturdy and holy personages astonished by all their feats in action: there were none of us who fought the Afghans better than they did. We all marched together during the night without molestation, until we arrived at a village near Kara Bagh. Here opposition commenced, and we advanced skirmishing until about 3 o’clock A.M., by which time our movements became generally known, and our enemies were gathering around us in hopeless numbers every minute. The road ran through the middle of Kara Bagh with walls and vineyards on either side: these the Afghans lined, and from them poured a deadly and frequent fire upon us. Numbers were killed, we were totally vanquished. There was a gateway into a vineyard on one side of the road. I rushed through it; an Afghan laid hold of my clothes to detain me, but I shook him off and continued my flight, taking care to carry my musket with me, for which I had only five rounds remaining in my pouch.

Approaching the British cantonment at dawn, Moti Ram realised that he had wandered into the middle of the besieging Afghan troops. ‘I saw at once that all hope of further escape was gone. I had one hundred rupees in my kummerbund, which sum I had amassed in the Shah’s service. I took it out and buried it, placing a stone which I thought I could recognise over it, and sat down quietly to await what might happen. Shortly after, a party of horse, about 25 in number approached the spot where I was. Some seized me by the feet, some by the shoulders.’[73] The Afghans tried to shoot Moti Ram with his own musket, but when it three times failed go off, the havildar told them he was a Muslim and that it was God’s will that he was not to be killed. He was asked to recite the Kalima, the Muslim profession of faith, and he did so.

> The sabre was then removed from my throat and they carried me to [their chief] Baha-ud-Din, first depriving me of my coat, pantaloons, a silk handkerchief, a pistol, my shoes and some other articles, leaving me only a pair of pyjamas. The people of the village continually threatened to put me to death, but Baha-ud-Din at length released me. I had proceeded a coss when a man ploughing on the roadside seized me, and threatened to kill me unless I worked his plough. Whilst I was with him, I suffered severely during the night time – the weather was bitter